

Physiotherapy for Arthritis — How It Helps and How to Access It

Everything you need to know about physiotherapy for arthritis: what it involves, NHS self-referral, private costs, hydrotherapy, and exercises you can do at home.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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If there is one healthcare professional every person with arthritis should know about, it is a physiotherapist. Physiotherapy is a cornerstone of arthritis treatment — recommended by NICE as a first-line approach for osteoarthritis, and a vital part of the multidisciplinary care recommended for rheumatoid arthritis. This guide explains exactly what physio can do for your joints, how to access it on the NHS, what private treatment costs, and what to expect at your first appointment.

What Can a Physiotherapist Do for Arthritis?

A physiotherapist is a movement and rehabilitation expert. They do far more than hand you a sheet of exercises. Their role includes: **comprehensive assessment** (looking at your whole body — how you walk, sit, stand, what muscles are weak or tight), **exercise prescription** (a personalised programme for your body, your joints, and your goals), **manual therapy** (hands-on techniques to mobilise stiff joints and release tight muscles), **pain management advice** (education on pacing, flare management, and using movement to reduce pain), **joint protection techniques** (teaching you how to move in ways that reduce strain on damaged joints), **gait re-training** (improving how you walk to reduce joint stress), and **referral and liaison** (connecting you with occupational therapy, orthopaedics, pain management programmes). UK physiotherapists are regulated by the Health and Care Professions Council (HCPC) and are often members of the Chartered Society of Physiotherapy (CSP). You are in safe hands.

Types of Physiotherapy for Arthritis



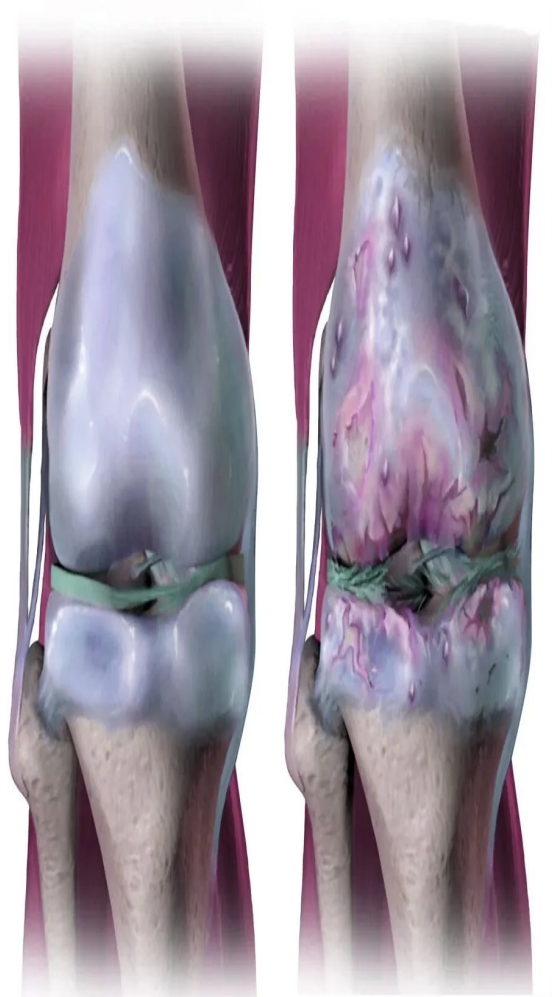
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Exercise-based physiotherapy is the bread and butter of arthritis care — your physio designs a programme of strengthening, flexibility, and balance exercises tailored to your joints and fitness level. **Manual therapy** involves hands-on joint mobilisation (gentle, controlled movements) and soft-tissue massage — providing short-term relief and helping you move more freely. Some NHS physiotherapists are trained in **acupuncture** — evidence for arthritis is mixed but some people find it helps. **Electrotherapy** (ultrasound, laser) is sometimes used though the evidence base is limited. Perhaps most importantly, **education and self-management** — your physio teaches you about your condition and gives you tools to manage it yourself, for life.

How to Get Physiotherapy on the NHS

There are two main routes. **Route 1 — GP referral:** your GP refers you to your local NHS physiotherapy service. The physiotherapy department contacts you with an appointment. **Route 2 — NHS MSK self-referral:** in many parts of the UK, you can refer yourself directly to an NHS musculoskeletal (MSK) physiotherapy service — no GP appointment needed. This is faster and takes pressure off GP surgeries.

NHS MSK Self-Referral — How It Works



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Self-referral (also called "self-refer" or "direct access") is available in many areas of England, Scotland, and Wales. Here is how: 1) Find your local service — search online for "NHS physiotherapy self-referral [your area]" or check your GP practice website. 2) Complete a form

— usually online but sometimes by phone — answering questions about your symptoms, general health, and what you need help with. 3) Triage — a physiotherapist reviews your form and decides if physiotherapy is appropriate and how quickly you need to be seen. 4) Appointment — if accepted, you receive an appointment, usually within a few weeks. Most adults with muscle or joint problems can self-refer. NHS physiotherapy is free at the point of use.

Private Physiotherapy — Costs and What to Expect

If NHS waiting times are long in your area or you want more frequent sessions, private physiotherapy is an option. Initial assessment costs £45–£80 and follow-up sessions cost £40–£65. Many clinics offer packages (e.g., 6 sessions for a reduced rate). Some health insurance policies cover physiotherapy. Look for HCPC registration (mandatory) and CSP membership with specialist interests (e.g., arthritis, rheumatology). The CSP "Physio2U" directory and "Physio First" network are good places to search. Private sessions usually offer longer appointments (45–60 minutes vs 20–30 minutes on NHS), more flexibility on appointment times (evenings, weekends), and continuity (same physio every time).

Hydrotherapy for Arthritis



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Hydrotherapy (aquatic physiotherapy) is performed in a warm-water pool (usually 33–36°C) with a physiotherapist guiding specific exercises. It is not just swimming. The water's buoyancy supports body weight, reducing stress on joints. The warmth relaxes muscles and eases stiffness. Moving through water strengthens muscles gently. Hydrotherapy is ideal if land-based exercise is too painful. Research shows it reduces pain and improves function in both OA and RA. It is available on the NHS in some areas (usually hospital physiotherapy departments), though access varies. Private hydrotherapy sessions cost £50–£80.

What to Expect at Your First Physio Appointment

Before you go: wear loose comfortable clothing, bring a list of your medications, and think about your goals (what would you like to be able to do that you cannot do now?). During the appointment (45–60 minutes): conversation about your pain, general health, work, hobbies, and what matters to you; physical assessment — you may be asked to walk, sit, stand, and

perform simple movements — the physio may gently feel your joints and test strength and range of motion (you can stop at any time); explanation of findings; and together you agree on a treatment plan — exercises, goals, and follow-up appointments. After: you will usually leave with 2–4 exercises to practise. Consistency is everything. Follow-up sessions every 2–4 weeks to check progress.

Q&A

Question: What Can a Physiotherapist Do for Arthritis?

Short answer: A physiotherapist is a movement and rehabilitation expert. They do far more than hand you a sheet of exercises. Their role includes: comprehensive assessment (looking at your whole body — how you walk, sit, stand, what muscles are weak or tight), exercise prescription (a personalised programme for your body, your joints, and your goals), manual therapy (hands-on techniques to mobilise stiff joints and release tight muscles), pain management advice

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk